

can be a life-changing realization. What you spend, not what you earn, determines how much you need to achieve FI. Understanding this simple concept can be incredibly empowering.

If you want a mansion, a country-club lifestyle, a new BMW every couple of years, and luxury travel at premium prices, you can do that. But you may actually need \$10 million to retire. What many people realize they actually want is a safe and comfortable place to live, the ability to spend time each week with friends, the time to enjoy travel as part of a flexible and adventurous lifestyle, and a safe car to get around in. You can have the second scenario for a fraction of the cost of the first *and* regain control of your life. That awareness can lead to the awakening that brings incredible peace and happiness instead of feelings of angst and hopelessness.

This exact sentiment was shared by another physician who blogs as *Physician on FIRE*. He previously projected his future investment values and realized he was on pace to have \$13 million by traditional retirement age. His awakening occurred when he realized, “Wait a second, I don’t need \$13 million.” He didn’t need to change anything he was doing. His awakening simply meant realizing his path to FI was realistic—and far shorter than he had imagined.